

THE UNDYING SOVEREIGN

D&D 5e Homebrew Class — Levels 1–20

A vessel of inherited cursed power. A lich who died before the dying.

CLASS OVERVIEW

The Undying Sovereign is a vessel — a living body that carries the fragmented soul-power of an ancient, death-transcending sorcerer. You have inherited techniques from multiple sources: the invisible slashing geometry of Severance and Rend, the rotational body-timing of the Lagging Strike, the explosive soulfire of Grave Flash, and a partial domain that crystallizes into the Sovereign's Tomb as your soul grows into its inheritance. You are not a spellcaster. You are not a martial fighter. You are something older than both.

Hit Die: *d10*

Primary Ability: *Intelligence*

Saving Throws: *Constitution and Intelligence*

Armor: *None — see Deathless Frame*

Weapons: *Simple weapons*

Skills: *Choose 3 from Arcana, Athletics, History, Insight, Intimidation, Investigation, Medicine, Perception, Stealth*

MALICE

Malice is the soul-stuff that fuels every technique you carry. It is not mana, not ki, not spell slots. It is the ambient energy of a death-touched, fractured soul pressed into the shape of power — and it is the only resource you have. There are no separate pools, no slot levels. You decide every turn how to spend it.

- **Pool Size:** (2 x your class level) + your Intelligence modifier, plus any bonuses from Crown Boons.
- **Long Rest:** Regain all expended Malice.
- **Short Rest:** Regain Malice equal to your proficiency bonus.
- **Kill Regen:** Whenever you reduce a creature to 0 hit points, regain 1 Malice immediately.

There are no slot levels and no recharge schedules beyond the above. The decision every turn is whether this moment is worth spending.

TECHNIQUE QUICK REFERENCE

All Malice-costing techniques listed here for easy reference during play. Full mechanical text appears in the Class Features section. The Sovereign's Tomb and The Undying King are outside the Malice economy and are not on this table.

Technique	Cost	Action Type	Effect
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Severance	0	Attack action	1d8 slashing or necrotic (your choice after 6th level), melee or 30 ft., Intelligence-based. Works with Extra Attack.
Counterflow	1+	Bonus action	Regain 1d8 + Int mod HP per Malice spent. Spend as much as you like in a single use.
Lagging Strike	2	On Severance hit	Mark the target. At the start of your next turn: 2d6 force damage, no roll, no save (3d6 at 11th, 4d6 at 17th). One mark at a time.
Rend	1–Prof	On Severance hit	+1d10 slashing per Malice spent. Maximum spend equals your proficiency bonus.
Grave Flash	1	Reaction (max-die trigger)	Trigger: you roll the maximum result on any damage die. Effect: +2d6 damage on that hit; advantage on Severance until end of next turn.
Deathless Grace	2	Reaction (attack trigger)	Trigger: an attack roll is made against you. Effect: the attacker has disadvantage on that roll.
Deathless Resolve	3	Reaction (0 HP trigger)	Trigger: you are reduced to 0 hit points. Effect: drop to 1 HP instead.
The Pale Dominion	4	Bonus action	10-ft. aura, 1 minute. Chosen creatures take Prof + Int slashing on entry or turn-start. Counterflow costs 0 Malice inside.

CLASS PROGRESSION

The Malice Bonus column shows Crown Boon additions only. Your base maximum is always (2 x class level) + Intelligence modifier in addition to any boon increases shown.

Lvl	Prof	Malice Bonus	Features
1	+2	Base: 2+Int	Deathless Frame, The Inherited Arsenal
2	+2	+Prof bonus	Sovereign's Oath, Declared Oaths, Counterflow
3	+2	—	Reliquary Feature, Lagging Strike
4	+2	—	Ability Score Improvement
5	+3	—	Extra Attack, Rend
6	+3	—	Eyes of the Hollow Soul, Grave Flash
7	+3	—	Reliquary Feature
8	+3	—	Ability Score Improvement, Deathless Grace
9	+4	—	Deathless Resolve
10	+4	—	Crowned Will, The Pale Dominion

11	+4	—	Adaptation, Sovereign's Edge (1d6)
12	+4	—	Ability Score Improvement
13	+5	—	Reliquary Feature
14	+5	—	Contempt for the Weak
15	+5	+Int mod	The Full Inheritance
16	+5	—	Ability Score Improvement
17	+6	—	Sovereign's Edge (1d8), The Sovereign's Tomb
18	+6	—	Reliquary Feature
19	+6	—	Ability Score Improvement
20	+6	—	The Undying King

CLASS FEATURES

1st Level

Deathless Frame

While not wearing armor and not wielding a shield, your AC equals 10 + your Dexterity modifier + your Intelligence modifier. You need only 4 hours of rest to benefit from a long rest. You have advantage on saving throws against disease and poison.

The Inherited Arsenal

At 1st level your Malice pool is established. Your maximum equals (2 x your class level) + your Intelligence modifier. You regain all Malice on a long rest, Malice equal to your proficiency bonus on a short rest, and 1 Malice whenever you reduce a creature to 0 hit points.

You also gain the **Severance** technique. When you take the Attack action, you may make Severance strikes in place of normal attacks. A Severance strike targets a creature at melee range or within 30 feet, uses your Intelligence modifier for both the attack and damage rolls, and deals 1d8 slashing damage on a hit. This damage is magical. Severance works with Extra Attack.

Severance costs 0 Malice. It is your baseline. Every other technique is a decision about whether this moment is worth spending more.

2nd Level

Sovereign's Oath

You swear that this vessel will carry one inheritance only. While you have levels in no class other than Undying Sovereign, you gain the Crown Boons listed below. If you ever gain a level in another class, this oath shatters permanently — you lose all Crown Boons already gained and cannot regain them, even if you never multiclass again.

- **2nd Level:** Your Malice maximum increases by your proficiency bonus.
- **10th Level:** Crowned Will (see below).
- **15th Level:** The Full Inheritance (see below).
- **20th Level:** The Undying King (see below).

The techniques you carry were inherited from a soul that knew no divided loyalties. They cooperate only for a singular host.

Declared Oaths

Once per short rest, as a bonus action, you may swear one of the following Declared Oaths. Each effect lasts until the start of your next turn unless otherwise noted.

- **Oath of Revelation:** Announce aloud the technique you intend to use next and what it will do. That technique deals maximum damage on all its dice. You cannot use that specific technique again until you finish a long rest.
- **Oath of the Stayed Hand:** You forgo your reaction until the start of your next turn. Your next Severance strike this turn scores a critical hit on a roll of 18–20.
- **Oath of the Open Hand:** (Gained at 15th level.) You cannot use Counterflow until you finish a long rest. Your next use of Rend this turn costs 0 Malice and deals one additional damage die.

At 15th level you may have two Declared Oaths active simultaneously, once per long rest.

Counterflow

As a bonus action, spend 1 or more Malice to channel reversed energy through your body and accelerate your own repair. For each point of Malice spent, you regain 1d8 + your Intelligence modifier hit points. You may spend as much Malice as you have available in a single use.

1 Malice is a patch. 4 or 5 Malice is emergency surgery. Inside The Pale Dominion, Counterflow costs 0 Malice.

3rd Level

Reliquary

At 3rd level, choose a Reliquary — the tradition through which you direct your inherited power's growth. Your Reliquary grants features at 3rd, 7th, 13th, and 18th level.

- **Reliquary of the Carved Throne.** Domain specialist. Plant yourself and make the battlefield your demiplane.
- **Reliquary of Twenty Vessels.** Tank specialist. Ablative blood vessels, sanguine control, and an impenetrable wall of resistances.
- **Reliquary of the Grave Pyre.** Blaster specialist. Seed black flame, build a charge over turns, and detonate everything.

Lagging Strike

When you hit a creature with a Severance strike, you may spend 2 Malice to mark that creature with a rotational burst. At the start of your next turn, the marked creature takes 2d6 force damage — no attack roll, no saving throw. You can have only one mark at a time; marking a new creature removes the previous mark without triggering its damage.

The burst damage increases to 3d6 at 11th level and 4d6 at 17th level.

4th Level

Ability Score Improvement

As normal for 5e. You may instead take a feat.

5th Level

Extra Attack

You can attack twice, instead of once, whenever you take the Attack action on your turn.

Rend

When you hit a creature with a Severance strike, you may spend up to a number of Malice equal to your proficiency bonus. For each point spent, the strike deals an additional 1d10 slashing damage.

Rend is your nova. At 5th level a full Rend spend on a single hit is comparable to a paladin smite. At 17th level inside the Sovereign's Tomb, Rend costs 0 Malice and your crit range is expanded. That is your endgame turn.

6th Level

Eyes of the Hollow Soul

You perceive creatures by their souls rather than their bodies. Within 30 feet, you see through illusions and shapeshifting, perceive invisible creatures (though they remain hidden for other purposes), and know instinctively whether a creature is below half its hit point maximum. Your Severance strikes can deal necrotic damage instead of slashing — your choice on each hit, declared before the roll.

Grave Flash

Whenever you roll the maximum result on any single damage die from a Severance strike, a Rend die, or a Lagging Strike burst, you may spend 1 Malice as a reaction. If you do, that damage instance deals an additional 2d6 damage of the same type, and you have advantage on all Severance attack rolls until the end of your next turn.

Grave Flash triggers on any individual max die, not only on a critical hit. Rolling an 8 on the d8 or a 10 on a Rend d10 both qualify. It is cheap by design. The question is always whether this particular moment is worth igniting.

7th Level

Reliquary Feature

Your Reliquary grants its second feature at 7th level.

8th Level

Ability Score Improvement

As normal.

Deathless Grace

Passive: When subjected to an effect that allows a Dexterity saving throw to take only half damage, you take no damage on a success and half damage on a failure.

Active: When an attack roll is made against you, you may spend 2 Malice as a reaction. The attacker has disadvantage on that roll.

The passive covers AoE and save-based damage. The active covers direct attacks. Together with Deathless Frame (AC) and Deathless Resolve (survive 0 HP), these three features are your complete survival suite.

9th Level

Deathless Resolve

When you are reduced to 0 hit points, you may spend 3 Malice as a reaction. If you do, you drop to 1 hit point instead. The lich does not die on someone else's schedule.

10th Level

Crowned Will (Crown Boon)

You are immune to the frightened condition and have advantage on saving throws against being charmed or possessed. Your soul has a king on its throne and nothing else fits there.

The Pale Dominion

As a bonus action, spend 4 Malice to surround yourself with a 10-foot-radius aura of invisible, whirring cuts for 1 minute. Designate any number of creatures when you create the aura; you may designate additional creatures as a free action on later turns. A designated creature that enters the aura for the first time on a turn or starts its turn there takes slashing damage equal to your proficiency bonus + your Intelligence modifier. While you are within the aura, Counterflow costs 0 Malice.

The Pale Dominion is an incomplete domain — a draft of the Sovereign's Tomb. It becomes whole at 17th level.

11th Level

Adaptation

Your body has died and rebuilt itself enough times that it has learned what hurts. You gain resistance to necrotic damage and to slashing damage from nonmagical weapons.

Sovereign's Edge

Your Severance strikes now deal an extra 1d6 necrotic damage on every hit, at no Malice cost. This is passive and always active. It increases to 1d8 at 17th level.

Sovereign's Edge ensures that even when you conserve Malice entirely, your at-will baseline has scaled meaningfully. Two Severance hits at level 11 deal $2 \times (1d8 + 1d6 + \text{Int mod})$ before any technique spending.

12th Level

Ability Score Improvement

As normal.

13th Level

Reliquary Feature

Your Reliquary grants its third feature at 13th level.

14th Level

Contempt for the Weak

When you hit with a Severance strike a creature that has fewer than half its hit points remaining, you may force it to make a Wisdom saving throw (DC 8 + proficiency bonus + Intelligence modifier). On a failure, it is frightened of you until the end of its next turn. You may use this feature a number of times equal to your Intelligence modifier (minimum 1), regaining all uses on a long rest.

15th Level

The Full Inheritance (Crown Boon)

Your Malice maximum increases by your Intelligence modifier, in addition to all previous increases. You learn the Oath of the Open Hand (see Declared Oaths above). Once per long rest, you may have two Declared Oaths active simultaneously.

*At level 15 with Int +5 and Prof +5: base pool is 30, +5 from 2nd-level boon, +5 from this boon = 40 Malice maximum.
Two Declared Oaths in the same round — Revelation and Stayed Hand together — is the intended power expression.*

16th Level

Ability Score Improvement

As normal.

17th Level

Sovereign's Edge Improvement

Sovereign's Edge now deals 1d8 necrotic damage per Severance hit instead of 1d6.

The Sovereign's Tomb

As an action, expend this feature to manifest a 30-foot-radius emanation centered on yourself for up to 1 minute. This requires no concentration and persists even while unconscious, ending only if you die. While active:

- Any creature you choose that starts its turn in the emanation or enters it for the first time on a turn takes necrotic damage equal to twice your Intelligence modifier + your proficiency bonus.
- Your Rend feature costs 0 Malice while you are within the emanation.
- Your Severance strikes score a critical hit on a roll of 19 or 20 against any creature below half its hit point maximum.
- Difficult terrain does not cost you extra movement while within the emanation.

You may use this feature once, regaining it when you finish a long rest.

The Sovereign's Tomb is outside the Malice economy. It is a separate category of power. The Undying King at 20th level makes it available on a short rest.

18th Level

Reliquary Feature

Your Reliquary grants its fourth and final feature at 18th level.

19th Level

Ability Score Improvement

As normal.

20th Level

The Undying King (Crown Boon)

Death has stopped asking your permission.

- The Sovereign's Tomb can now be used once per short or long rest, instead of once per long rest.
- While The Sovereign's Tomb is active, you have resistance to all damage.
- Once per long rest, when you would be reduced to 0 hit points, you instead drop to 1 hit point and regain all expended Malice.

Deathless Resolve (3 Malice, reactive) and The Undying King (1/long rest, free, refills the pool) both protect you from dying. Surviving a killing blow to return with a full Malice pool and an active Tomb is the intended 20th-level power fantasy.

RELIQUARY OF THE CARVED THRONE

Plant yourself. Make the battlefield yours.

You commit to a piece of ground and turn it into a demiplane of punishment. Moving through your space hurts. Trying to leave gets punished. Your domain is not a spell slot or a limited resource — it is a posture, a vow of stillness that the power inside you rewards with total territorial control.

3rd Level — Sovereign's Ground

As a bonus action, designate the area within 15 feet of your current position as your territory. This designation lasts until you voluntarily move from your space or are incapacitated. While active:

- Creatures you designate treat the territory as difficult terrain.
- When a designated creature hits you with a melee attack while inside the territory, it takes slashing damage equal to your Intelligence modifier.

Sovereign's Ground costs no Malice — the cost is the commitment to standing still. When you gain The Pale Dominion at 10th level, its radius is 20 feet instead of 10.

7th Level — Inescapable Domain

When a creature within your Sovereign's Ground or The Pale Dominion attempts to move out of that area, you can use your reaction to make one Severance strike against it. On a hit, its speed drops to 0 until the start of its next turn.

While Sovereign's Ground is active you also have advantage on saving throws and ability checks to resist being moved from your space: pushed, pulled, grappled, or otherwise.

This reaction competes with Deathless Grace and Deathless Resolve. Choosing between punishing a fleeing enemy and surviving a hit is the intended tension for this subclass.

13th Level — Carved Dominion

Your territory develops active hunger. Once per round, when a creature takes damage from The Pale Dominion or The Sovereign's Tomb, you can spend 1 Malice as a free action to force it to make a Strength saving throw (DC 8 + proficiency bonus + Intelligence modifier). On a failure, choose: push it 15 feet directly away from you, or pull it 15 feet directly toward you.

While Sovereign's Ground is active you also know the exact location of every creature within 30 feet of you, regardless of invisibility or cover. Your territory reports to you.

18th Level — The Eternal Throne

Your Sovereign's Tomb becomes a true demiplane. While it is active:

- The emanation's radius is 60 feet instead of 30 feet.
- Creatures that fail the Carved Dominion Strength save are also restrained until the end of their next turn.
- When a creature is reduced to 0 hit points within the emanation, you regain Malice equal to your proficiency bonus.
- You have advantage on all saving throws while within the emanation.

60 feet covers most combat areas at typical table sizes. At tier 4, the Carved Throne player should functionally own the room.

RELIQUARY OF TWENTY VESSELS

You are a wall. You do not die. You outlast.

You are not the fastest or the most explosive option in any given combat. You are the one still standing when everything else has fallen. Your blood hardens into ablative layers. Your body accrues resistance after resistance. By 18th level, breaking through your defenses is a problem most enemies at the table cannot solve.

3rd Level — Sanguine Vessel

You gain the **Sanguine Coil** technique: as an action, spend 2 Malice. A tendril of directed blood strikes a target within 30 feet for 2d6 piercing or necrotic damage (your choice). The target must succeed on a Strength saving throw (DC 8 + proficiency bonus + Intelligence modifier) or be restrained until the end of its next turn. A restrained target also has disadvantage on attack rolls against any creature other than you until the restraint ends.

Additionally, during a long rest you can harden fragments of your blood into ablative layers called **Carved Vessels**. You can have a number of Carved Vessels equal to your proficiency bonus. When you take damage, you may shatter one as a reaction to reduce that damage by 1d10 + your Intelligence modifier. Each shattered vessel is gone until your next long rest.

The taunt on the Strength save failure is built into the restraint: the creature cannot move toward anyone else and has disadvantage attacking them. Sanguine Coil + Sovereign's Ground from the base class is a particularly effective combination.

7th Level — Vessel's Constitution

Your hit point ceiling rises significantly. You gain 2 additional maximum hit points for each level you have in this class, applied retroactively. This stacks with the Tough feat.

You also gain resistance to poison damage and immunity to the poisoned condition. Your body is half-dead and it knows it.

13th Level — Blood Aegis

As a bonus action, spend 2 Malice to raise a hardened blood shield. You gain temporary hit points equal to 2d10 + your Intelligence modifier.

Additionally, when an enemy destroys one of your Carved Vessels directly, that creature immediately takes necrotic damage equal to your proficiency bonus. Breaking your defenses hurts.

18th Level — Undying Bulwark

You gain resistance to bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage from all sources, magical or otherwise. Once per round, when you take damage, you may reduce that damage by your proficiency bonus before resistances are applied.

Combined with Adaptation (necrotic and nonmagical slashing resistance), Vessel's Constitution (bonus HP), Blood Aegis (temporary HP), and Carved Vessel reduction — a 20th-level Twenty Vessels player is among the most durable creatures in 5e at the same tier.

RELIQUARY OF THE GRAVE PYRE

Seed it. Charge it. Detonate everything.

You are a furnace. Your body carries black flame — not ordinary fire, but the cursed burning of a soul-inherited technique — and you seed it across targets, compress it inside yourself over multiple turns, and release it in a detonation that ends fights. The Grave Pyre is about patience and payoff: two or three turns of careful setup followed by one turn that the table will remember.

3rd Level — Grave Flame

When you hit a creature with a Severance strike, you can spend 1 Malice to ignite it with Grave Flame. An ignited creature takes fire damage equal to your Intelligence modifier at the start of each of its turns. A creature can carry only one Grave Flame at a time. The ignition lasts until the target or an ally within reach spends an action to smother it, or until it is consumed by another Grave Pyre feature. You can have a number of creatures simultaneously ignited equal to your proficiency bonus.

You also gain resistance to fire damage. Your body is the furnace. Fire does not frighten it.

7th Level — Pyre Charge

As a bonus action, spend 1 or more Malice — up to your proficiency bonus per use — to compress black flame inside your body. Each point of Malice adds one Charge Die (d8 fire) to your current charge. You can build your charge across multiple turns. Total accumulated Charge Dice cannot exceed your proficiency bonus. The charge persists until you release it or finish a rest.

When you hit a creature with a Severance strike, you can release your entire charge as part of that hit. The target takes fire damage equal to all Charge Dice + your Intelligence modifier in addition to the Severance damage. If the target is currently ignited with Grave Flame, the ignition is consumed and the Charge Dice damage is doubled.

The tension is real every turn: 1 Malice seeds a Grave Flame for future payoff; 3 Malice into the charge now means your next hit is enormous; holding the charge for a second turn to max it is the patient play. You are choosing between three different kinds of investment on every bonus action.

13th Level — Open

Once per short rest, when you would release a Pyre Charge by hitting a creature, you may instead declare Open before rolling the charge damage. The release erupts outward. Every creature of your choice within 30 feet takes fire damage equal to your accumulated Charge Dice + your Intelligence modifier. Each creature may make a Dexterity saving throw (DC 8 + proficiency bonus + Intelligence modifier) for half damage. Creatures currently ignited with Grave Flame automatically fail this saving throw and have their ignition consumed.

Open is your earned AoE. You built the charge across two turns and seeded ignitions across the battlefield. Now everything in 30 feet eats the release simultaneously — and the ignited creatures never get a save.

18th Level — Conflagration

As an action, every creature you have ignited with Grave Flame simultaneously detonates. Each takes 6d10 fire damage — no attack roll, no saving throw. Each ignition is consumed. You may use Conflagration once per long rest.

At maximum ignitions with proficiency bonus +6, that is 6 creatures each taking 6d10 fire with no save. The total expected output exceeds most 9th-level spells. It requires setup. It rewards it proportionally.